

7/13 – Moving Fast with CST, Understanding Feedback in Software Development & Feedback Project Intro, Designing Effective Feedback Mechanisms

Moving Fast with CST

Speakers: James Buxton, Matt Carapallo, Dave Crosser (recorded), CST Team

Team Structure and Roles

- The customer success team (CST) sits between support and professional services, offering consultative guidance without the cost of a paid engagement or the narrow scope of a support ticket
- Strategic solutions managers (SSMs) make up the bulk of the team and work directly with clients on best practices, training, and feature rollouts
- The client partner group handles contracts, renewals, and upsells, and was folded into CST in 2026
- Renewals staff serve as the first point of contact for new customers and help guide clients toward the right internal team during the renewal process
- All CST services are included in a customer subscription at no additional cost, and customers are encouraged to use the team as often as needed

CET vs CST: History and Evolution

- The team began in 2018 as the client engagement team (CET), formed to help customers adapt to a major price increase paired with new features
- In 2021, the team was renamed the client experience team, shifting focus toward understanding the customer experience and feeding that insight back to the company
- In 2022, a community engagement function was added, eventually growing into user groups and a strategic advisory network
- In 2023, the team added support for Colleague, a different underlying system than the company's primary product base, in order to serve that segment more effectively
- In 2026, the team was renamed the customer success team (CST) and merged with the client partner group, adding renewal and upsell responsibilities to its existing technical and training role
- The team has changed names and scope repeatedly since 2018 in order to stay aligned with company growth and evolving customer needs

Core Responsibilities

- Conduct regular check-ins with customers to understand usage, frustrations, and underused features
- Escalate complex or stalled support tickets to engineering when needed
- Connect customers with similar goals or challenges to one another to build community
- Run beta programs, gathering feedback from select customers on features that are not yet fully built
- Act as an advocacy bridge, surfacing customer feedback to product, engineering, and other internal teams
- Help customers stay confident with the product after implementation through refreshers, walkthroughs, and tailored guidance sessions

Team Mission and Goals

- The team positions itself as the customer's biggest advocate within the company
- A recurring theme is high staff turnover at client institutions, which the team addresses through training sessions and a newer user group aimed at newcomers
- The team's core mission centers on gathering feedback consistently and making sure it reaches the right internal teams to influence product decisions
- Trust is described as the most important outcome of the relationship, since customers want to know they have an advocate who understands their goals

Understanding Feedback in Software Development

Speakers: Peter, Ann Sanchez, Jackie Fleming

Why Feedback Matters

- It is tempting to assume what a client wants without confirming it, which can lead to building the wrong thing
- Feedback improves the user experience by surfacing friction points that internal assumptions miss
- Feedback helps align feature priorities with what customers actually need instead of guessing
- Products that reflect real user needs see stronger adoption, since users are more likely to stick with a tool that solves their actual problem
- Catching problems early through feedback reduces development cost and rework, which speeds up the overall development process
- Companies that consistently listen and respond to users build a competitive advantage that is difficult for competitors to replicate

Real World Example: Cadmus vs Argos X

- **Cadmus** was launched without early client input or testing, based on an assumed need that turned out to be weaker than expected
- The lack of early feedback led to confusion for clients and added stress, and issues were only discovered after launch
- **Argos X** took the opposite approach, incorporating surveys, focus groups, and in-app analytics before and during development
- Early beta testing with real users surfaced several hundred issues before launch, leading to a smoother release
- The tradeoff was a heavier lift in time and coordination, and some early signals were still missed due to limited alignment with the support team
- The overall lesson is that involving users early and often catches more problems, even though the process requires more time and effort

Feedback Project Intro: Group Activity

- Interns split into pairs to brainstorm a feedback collection method for the Dashboard Designer project
- Each group addressed three questions: what method would be used, how results would be collected, and how participants would be identified
- Groups also addressed how success would be measured for their chosen method
- Methods proposed across groups included an in-app feedback widget, a post-ticket satisfaction survey, virtual focus groups with a follow-up survey, and one-on-one client meetings
- A recurring theme was the importance of using multiple identification methods rather than relying on just one, such as combining active users, support ticket submitters, and people

who have never engaged with the product at all

- Facilitators noted that customers who have never logged in or submitted a ticket are a meaningful at-risk group worth identifying separately
- A caution raised was the risk of over-relying on a small number of highly enthusiastic users, since their feedback may not represent the broader customer base
- Facilitators also discussed the importance of respecting user privacy when using activity or usage data to identify participants, rather than making customers feel monitored

Designing Effective Feedback Mechanisms

Speakers: Peter, Ann Sanchez, Jackie Fleming

Starting with Why

- Before writing any questions, it is important to define why the feedback tool is being created in the first place
- Skipping this step risks collecting data that does not actually inform any decision
- The intended use of the feedback should guide who is asked, what is asked, and how the results are analyzed

Four Principles of Good Feedback Design

- **Be specific and actionable** – overly general questions produce overly general answers that cannot be acted on
- **Anchor in the specific** – ground questions in a particular feature or interaction rather than the product as a whole, since a concrete anchor produces a more concrete answer
- **Ask diagnostic questions** – good feedback explains why something worked or did not, not just whether it worked
- **Focus on the work, not the interviewee** – keep the conversation centered on the product or experience rather than the person, which keeps responses honest and prevents defensiveness

Open-Ended vs Closed-Ended Questions

- **Open-ended questions** invite detailed, explanatory responses and cannot be answered with a single word, such as asking what someone thought about a new feature rather than whether they liked it
- **Closed-ended questions** produce quick, easy to tally responses, such as yes or no questions or a numeric rating scale, but they do not explain the reasoning behind the answer
- Both question types are useful depending on the goal, but open-ended questions are needed to uncover the deeper why behind a response

Interview Script Group Activity and Peer Review

- Groups drafted an interview script of at least five questions to gather feedback on the Dashboard Designer project, without using AI assistance
- Scripts were shared with the full group for peer review and refinement
- Common feedback across scripts included avoiding redundant questions that ask the same thing in different words
- Leading language should be avoided, such as replacing a phrasing like how information could be presented differently with a more neutral, open version that does not assume dissatisfaction
- The word problem should generally be avoided in favor of challenge, since problem can feel personal and narrows responses toward technical issues rather than broader factors such as staffing or resources
- Using conversational prompts such as tell me about or walk me through tends to open people

up more than a direct question

- Customers are generally strong at identifying problems but less reliable at proposing solutions, so feedback should be received graciously without over-relying on suggested fixes
- Interviewers should stay flexible and follow the natural flow of the conversation rather than rigidly working through every question in order
- If a conversation goes off track into an important but unrelated topic, it is reasonable to acknowledge it and suggest addressing it in a separate follow-up conversation
- The right level of detail in a question depends on who is being interviewed, since a frontline user may respond well to detailed product questions while a more senior stakeholder may respond better to higher-level questions

Homework: AI Persona Practice

- Each group was assigned one of four AI personas to test their interview script against: Amanda, an admissions staff member, Tom, a director of student life, Tina, an events director, and Christine, a board member
- Groups were instructed to paste the persona background into an AI tool such as Claude, then ask their interview questions and observe how the persona responded
- Groups were asked to capture how the persona's responses changed as the script was revised, and to be ready to present their findings the next day

7/14 – Client Partner Overview, Testing and Refining Feedback Tools, Planning Feedback Implementation, User Groups Overview & Dovetail Demo

Client Partner Role in Renewals

Speaker: Dave Clark, Manager of Client Engagement and Success

- The client partner team protects existing revenue across the company's active customer accounts, focusing on contracts, renewals, and licenses
- Each account is assigned both a client partner, who handles the business and contract side, and an SSM, who handles the technical side
- Three client partners cover roughly 300 to 350 accounts each, working closely with SSMs to coordinate technical and contractual conversations
- Industry standard churn for annual recurring revenue in software is generally under 10 percent, and this team targets 2.5 to 3 percent
- Renewal conversations begin 6 to 8 months before a contract expires in order to identify risk early and leave time to resolve issues
- Accounts are segmented by revenue, strategic importance, and user group involvement to determine how frequently they should be contacted
- Client partners also refer expansion opportunities, such as new products, to the sales team when a customer expresses interest
- Face-to-face relationship building with customers is treated as a key differentiator compared to companies that rely mainly on automated support

Testing and Refining Feedback Tools

Speakers: Peter, Hannah, Jackie Fleming

Homework Debrief: AI Persona Testing

- Groups shared strengths and challenges from testing their interview scripts against an assigned AI persona overnight
- A common challenge was a persona giving vague or repetitive answers, such as citing limited technical comfort, which limited the depth of feedback on the product itself
- A common strength was that scripts still surfaced useful feature preferences even without an actual product in front of the persona
- Personas that were more detail oriented gave sharper feedback once follow-up questions were asked, rather than in the initial response

Principles for Testing Feedback Tools

- Knowing when enough responses have been collected depends on hearing answers begin to repeat, rather than reaching a specific number
- Quality should be prioritized over quantity, since a smaller number of thoughtful, detailed responses is often more useful than many brief ones
- Interviews should stay short and focused so participants are more likely to complete them and stay on topic
- Questions should use clear, plain language and avoid technical terms or jargon that could confuse a respondent
- Explaining why feedback is being requested helps participants understand the purpose and take the request more seriously

Peer Testing Activity

- Interns tested their interview scripts on each other in pairs, checking each question for bias, openness, and specificity
- Testing against a colleague, in addition to an AI persona, surfaced differences in how much technical background a question assumed
- Based on both rounds of testing, each group made a final round of edits to their script

Script Revisions and Key Adjustments

- One group generalized a question that had originally listed three specific check-in methods into a single open version, allowing the respondent to describe their own approach
- Another group split a compound question into two, since usefulness and frequency of use are not always the same thing, and added a request to explain why, turning a closed question into an open one
- A group revised a question that was originally framed around beta testing into a more generic version appropriate for any user
- A group reconsidered the word inappropriate in a data visibility question, discussing whether against policy would be a clearer and less subjective alternative
- A group revised a generic success metrics question into one asking what would convince a specific stakeholder, such as a board member, that the product was successful after one year, producing a more specific and actionable answer

Planning Feedback Implementation

Speakers: Ann Sanchez, Jackie Fleming, James Buxton

The Implementation Lifecycle

- A feedback tool creates no value if it is never launched or acted upon
- The lifecycle includes five steps: plan, launch, collect, analyze, and act, followed by a return

to planning

- Planning involves identifying the audience and mapping out a timeline before launching anything
- Launching means distributing the tool to the right audience through the right channel
- Collecting means gathering responses as they come in
- Analyzing means interpreting both quantitative data, such as ratings, and qualitative data, such as written responses, while avoiding analysis paralysis or acting on too little data
- Acting means making an actual change based on what was learned, closing the loop with participants, and documenting the process for future cycles
- The lifecycle is circular rather than linear, since acting on feedback should lead back into planning the next round

Common Rollout Pitfalls

- Sending a survey with no clear deadline, which causes responses to be delayed indefinitely
- Failing to plan for follow-up reminders, since a single invitation rarely produces an adequate response rate
- Choosing a distribution method that does not match the audience, such as email for a group that rarely checks it

Writing a Strong Invitation

- A good invitation is short, honest, and specific
- It should clearly state what is being collected, why it matters, and what will happen with the results
- Tone matters as much as content, since a genuine and respectful message produces better response rates than one that feels like a form letter

Quantitative vs Qualitative Data

- Quantitative data includes anything that can be counted, such as ratings or yes or no responses, and is analyzed by looking for patterns and trends
- Qualitative data includes written responses and interview answers, and is analyzed by reading through responses and grouping similar ideas together
- Saturation, meaning the point where responses start repeating rather than introducing new ideas, signals that enough data has been collected

Closing the Loop

- Collecting feedback and doing nothing with it is worse than not collecting it at all, since it erodes trust and makes participants feel their time was wasted
- Acting on feedback does not require implementing every suggestion, but it does require acknowledging what was heard, explaining what will or will not be done, and making at least some change
- Communicating results back to participants, even briefly, shows that their input mattered
- Documenting the process, including timelines, response rates, and what worked or did not work, makes future feedback cycles more efficient

Prioritization and Real-World Complexity

- Not every piece of feedback requires the full lifecycle, since small fixes such as typos can often be resolved quickly outside the formal process
- What looks like a simple fix to a user, such as adjusting a filter, can involve significant underlying complexity once the product team investigates it
- SSMs act as client advocates, balancing what a client is asking for against product and

engineering priorities, and documenting requests that cannot be addressed immediately so they are not lost over time

- Feedback from a smaller or differently situated group, such as a finance department, can reveal priorities completely different from the primary audience a company usually hears from
- Internal teams do not always agree on product decisions either, and client feedback is sometimes used to resolve internal disagreements about how a feature should work

User Groups Overview & Dovetail Demo

Speaker: James Buxton

Argos X Academy Videos

- The customer success team built a series of short, on-demand training videos to drive adoption of Argos X, the newer cloud-based product, over the older Argos Web Viewer
- Long-form training that once ran about an hour was broken into short, sequential video chapters, generally five minutes or less, so customers can watch only what is relevant to them
- Scripts were adapted from existing SSM training material and rewritten with AI assistance to sound more encouraging and instructional rather than directive
- The video library grows over time as new features are released, giving both new and existing customers a lasting, self-service reference

User Groups vs Strategic Advisory Network

- **User groups** are open to all customers and meet quarterly, combining product updates, client-led presentations, and open discussion so customers can learn from one another and from the company
- User groups are organized by segment, including groups for brand-new customers, more advanced users, Colleague-specific customers, customers transitioning to SaaS, and several regional or language-based groups
- Regional user groups are adjusted or paused based on real-world factors such as regional instability or shifting business priorities, and attendance data is reviewed regularly to decide where to invest
- **The Strategic Advisory Network (SAN)** is a smaller, invitation-based group made up of higher education technology leaders such as CIOs and directors of applications
- SAN sessions focus on strategic topics such as AI adoption and data governance rather than hands-on training, and give members early insight into upcoming product plans
- SAN findings are compiled into a polished, formal summary report with key themes, quotes, and next steps, which is shared with participants and also used as a credibility tool with prospective members
- The core difference between the two groups is audience level, since user groups serve hands-on, day-to-day users while SAN serves strategic decision makers

Measuring User Group Impact

- Key metrics tracked include repeat attendance rate, total number of institutions represented, and the percentage of top-revenue accounts participating in a group
- Low participation among top accounts is treated as a priority signal, since retention risk for a high-revenue account carries more financial weight than for a smaller account
- Attendance by prospective customers at a user group is tracked and passed to sales as a strong signal of buying interest
- Metrics and reporting are used to justify continued investment in user groups and to decide which regional or niche groups to pause or expand

Post-Meeting Follow-Up

- After each meeting, the team compiles a recap using the meeting transcript and shares it with attendees, including links to resources or data blocks discussed
- Internally, a short summary highlighting key themes and quotes is shared with the broader company so other departments understand what customers are saying
- Direct quotes from satisfied customers are collected and reused in marketing and sales conversations

Dovetail Preface

- Dovetail served as the central repository for recordings of customer meetings, user group sessions, and SAN meetings
- The platform transcribed recordings and used AI to auto-tag sections of conversation by topic, such as best practices or specific features
- Tagging made it possible to generate a report of everything said about a given topic across many conversations, including sentiment trends over time
- The team noted that Dovetail may be phased out in the future, but the underlying practice of recording, transcribing, and tagging customer conversations for company-wide use is expected to continue in some form

Final Debrief

All Participants

- Different customers need different types of engagement, so understanding each stakeholder's role helps build stronger relationships
- Collecting data only creates value once it leads to actionable insight, so asking the right questions and presenting results clearly matters as much as collection itself
- Wording matters, since different customers can interpret the same question differently, so care is needed in how questions are phrased
- Active listening is essential, since customers do not always articulate the real issue directly, and follow-up questions are often needed to find the actual concern
- Combining qualitative and quantitative methods produces a more complete picture than relying on one type of data alone
- Routing feedback to the correct internal team, such as product, engineering, or professional services, remains an ongoing operational challenge even after feedback has been collected

7/15 – Sales Kickoff, Art of the Software Demo, From Data to Decisions, Sales and Technical Teams

Sales Kickoff

Speakers: Luis Garcia, Mike Ruzik, Paul, Brendan Paul, Jared Petrie, Jose, Shane

- The sales team introduced its structure, including account executives, who own the business relationship, and solutions engineers, who own the technical side of a sale
- Several sales team members previously worked in support before moving into sales, showing that career paths within the company are not always linear
- In-person, on-campus demos close at a noticeably higher rate than fully virtual ones, since face-to-face meetings build trust and a sense of obligation more effectively
- Credibility is the main reason a school agrees to bring a salesperson on campus, since the person making the introduction is putting their own reputation on the line

- Protecting time is treated as one of the most important disciplines in sales, since time spent on a deal that will not close is time taken away from deals that could
- Keeping cameras on during virtual meetings is viewed as essential for building trust, and its absence is seen as a red flag by prospects
- Keeping an audience engaged on a video call requires actively using names, previewing who will speak next, and asking direct questions throughout rather than presenting for long stretches uninterrupted
- Reviewing a prospect's LinkedIn profile ahead of a call can surface shared connections or background that helps open a conversation naturally

Art of the Software Demo

Speakers: Paul, Osandy

Why Demos Fail

- Demos rarely fail because the software is not good enough, and more often fail because of how the demo itself is delivered
- Common mistakes include showing too many features at once, overwhelming the audience instead of focusing on what matters to them specifically
- Talking too fast or too technically for the audience in the room is a common issue, especially for presenters who know the product deeply
- Being unprepared or not testing the software beforehand is one of the most damaging mistakes, since technical issues undermine confidence in the product itself

Tell a Story, Not a Tour

- Customers do not care where menus are located, they care about whether their specific problem gets solved
- An effective demo is built like a story, starting with where the customer is today, moving through their challenge, and ending with how the product solves it
- A discovery call before the demo is essential for gathering the information needed to build that story, including the customer's pain points, goals, and who will attend the demo
- Good discovery relies on open-ended questions rather than yes or no questions, since open questions let the conversation flow naturally and reveal more
- Referencing similar schools or comparable use cases during a demo helps build credibility and makes the story more relatable

Know Your Audience

- Different departments require different types of demos, since an IT-heavy audience wants technical detail while an executive audience wants business outcomes
- Executives generally care about return on investment, time savings, risk reduction, and strategic value rather than technical mechanics
- A useful test is whether a ten-year-old could follow the explanation, since demos that are too complex lose the audience regardless of technical accuracy

Keeping Everyone Engaged

- Calling out specific attendees by name and tying content back to what they said earlier keeps individuals engaged even when the topic does not directly involve them
- Comfortable use of silence, even for ten to fifteen seconds, can prompt a hesitant participant to speak up
- Simple, plain language works better than technical jargon, even with a technical audience,

since jargon risks losing people unnecessarily

Handling Curveballs

- When a question is unclear, the first step is to repeat it back to confirm understanding before answering
- If the answer is known, it should be delivered confidently, but if it is not known, the honest response is to say so and follow up afterward rather than guessing
- Guessing or making up an answer risks losing credibility and trust, which are difficult to recover once lost
- If the answer to a tough question is genuinely yes, a simple, confident yes is usually more effective than over-explaining, which can create unnecessary follow-up questions
- Following up in writing within 24 hours after a call reinforces that the customer's questions were taken seriously

Preparing Your Demo

- Demos should be run against realistic environments, such as real banner or Colleague system connections, so the demo reflects how the product actually performs
- Reports that take a long time to load should be pre-run rather than demonstrated live, since a slow load creates doubt even when the delay is not representative of normal use
- Having a backup plan for technical issues, and the ability to pivot smoothly if something breaks, keeps a demo from derailing
- Teams typically meet several times before a major demo to divide roles, choose which data blocks to show, and align on messaging
- Mistakes during a live demo should be handled quietly and without drawing attention, similar to an actor recovering from a missed line on stage
- Three core principles were emphasized: less is more, tell the story, and practice out loud before the actual call
- A typical demo runs about an hour to an hour and fifteen minutes, though highly technical audiences with detailed questions can extend a demo to two hours

Reflections on Sales as a Career

- Rejection is a constant part of sales, and outcomes ultimately depend on decisions made by other people, not just the salesperson's effort
- Sales results are highly visible and tied directly to a number, unlike many other departments where success is more nuanced
- Maintaining a strong, active pipeline helps offset the natural ups and downs of individual deals falling through

From Data to Decisions

Speakers: Osandy, Shane

The Higher Education Data Challenge

- The core challenge in higher education is not a lack of data, but the fact that data lives scattered across many separate systems
- Each department, such as the registrar, finance, and HR, owns its own piece of the institutional story, which creates data silos and inconsistent definitions
- Combining data manually across systems requires significant repetitive work, such as merging spreadsheets by hand

SIS, LMS, and CRM

- **SIS (Student Information System)** is the official system of record, covering registration, grades, billing, financial aid, and core student records
- **LMS (Learning Management System)**, such as Canvas or Blackboard, covers the classroom experience, including assignments, attendance, and quizzes
- **CRM** covers recruitment and communications, tracking prospective students, applications, and outreach before a student enrolls
- Each system holds only part of the full student story, which is why connecting them together matters more than any single system alone

The Data Warehouse

- A data warehouse is a central location where data from multiple systems is copied and optimized for reporting and analytics, rather than for daily transactions
- Reporting directly against live production systems is inefficient and risky, so data is copied into the warehouse instead
- A data warehouse does not analyze data on its own, it simply brings information together so that a tool such as Argos can run analysis against consistent, trusted data

Reporting vs Analytics

- **Reporting** answers what happened, such as how many students enrolled or which courses are full
- **Analytics** goes further, looking for patterns, trends, and predictions to help guide what should happen next
- A useful summary is that reporting explains the past, while analytics helps guide the future

Supporting Student Success

- A student's full story is spread across many systems, including attendance, LMS engagement, grades, holds, balances, and even campus card activity
- Individually, these data points reveal little, but connected together they can surface at-risk students earlier
- Rather than requiring advisors to log into four different systems, tools like the student success accelerator bring this information into one place so advisors can take a proactive approach

Executive Dashboards

- Different roles need different views of data, since advisors need student-level detail, department chairs need operational reports, and executives need a small set of trusted, high-level metrics
- Executives generally do not want dozens of reports, they want five or six key performance indicators they trust and can act on quickly
- Common executive metrics include retention, enrollment, graduation rate, revenue, and student engagement or satisfaction
- Dashboard tools can surface these metrics automatically in one place, giving leadership a real-time view without waiting on custom reports

AI and Natural Language

- Historically, getting a report required going through IT or institutional research and waiting for someone to build it
- AI tools now allow a user to ask a plain-language question and get an answer without needing to understand database structure or write queries

- This shifts IT's time away from routine reporting requests and toward more strategic work, while giving departments faster answers
- A tool like Argos has already been reducing dependence on IT for reporting for years, and AI is described as the next layer making that same self-service experience even easier
- Relying entirely on AI answers without also developing independent reasoning skills was raised as a caution, particularly for students still building foundational knowledge

Argos in Action

- Argos is positioned as bringing together everything discussed: connecting data across systems, building dashboards for leadership, and making reporting accessible through AI
- The stated goal is to get the right information to the right people at the right time so that better decisions can be made
- The team frames its work not just as building reports, but as helping institutions turn data into decisions

Sales and Technical Teams

Speakers: Brendan Paul, Jared Petrie

Meet the Team

- A software purchase typically involves several roles working together, including the account executive, solutions engineer, professional services, customer success, support, and engineering
- The customer sits at the center of this process, since no single team can create a strong customer experience alone, only a coordinated one can

Account Executive vs Solutions Engineer

- The **account executive (AE)** owns the business side of a deal, including prospecting, relationship building, negotiation, and pipeline forecasting
- The **solutions engineer (SE)** owns the technical side, building trust by understanding the institution's technical environment, validating that the software will work, and demonstrating the solution
- The two roles overlap in practice, since SEs also build relationships with customers over time, not just AEs
- Close alignment and communication between the AE and SE is essential, since visible disagreement in front of a customer damages credibility for both roles

Sales Myths vs Reality

- **Myth: sales is about convincing people to buy** – reality: a good AE is not trying to win every deal, only the right deals where the product is genuinely a fit
- **Myth: sales is all about quotas** – reality: sales is built on long-term relationships, which often lead to referrals as contacts move between institutions
- **Myth: the AE and SE work separately** – reality: they collaborate daily and prep before every call to stay aligned
- **Myth: customers buy the product** – reality: customers are buying a solution to an existing problem, not features for their own sake

The Opportunity Lifecycle

- The account executive is the first point of contact, qualifying the prospect before looping in the solutions engineer
- The solutions engineer handles discovery and the technical demonstration, drawing on as much context as possible from the AE to avoid wasting the prospect's time

- Once the prospect is ready to move forward, the deal moves to an agreement and contract signature
- After signing, the account moves to the client partner and customer success team for implementation and long-term account management
- Taking detailed notes throughout the process is important, since prospects in higher education are often slow to respond due to competing priorities

Deal Strategy

- **Internal planning** – align the AE and SE early, define what success looks like, and assign clear ownership of tasks
- **Competitive positioning** – understand competitors without disparaging them directly, and use any gaps a prospect mentions as an opportunity to highlight strengths
- **Risk management** – identify potential blockers early, build a mitigation plan, and review the deal's status regularly
- Being transparent when an answer is not known, rather than guessing, is consistently more effective at building trust than appearing to know everything

Technical Credibility

- Confident, direct language builds trust with technical stakeholders such as CIOs and system administrators, while soft or uncertain language undermines it
- Asking specific technical questions about a prospect's environment, such as hosting setup, demonstrates genuine understanding and reduces the risk of promising something that will not work
- Building trust and reducing risk during the sales process directly supports higher win rates and a smoother path to implementation

After the Signature

- Three teams take over after a deal closes: professional services handles implementation and training, customer success manages ongoing goals and renewal planning, and support provides ongoing technical help
- These teams collaborate throughout the full customer lifecycle from initial signature through renewal and beyond
- Customer success stays engaged after the sale to ensure the customer is using the product to its full potential, which supports both satisfaction and renewal

Lessons Learned

- Staying consistently on top of an opportunity is critical, since a promising prospect can go cold quickly if follow-up lapses
- A structured, repeatable outreach process, such as call, voicemail, then email, helps maintain consistency without sounding scripted
- Confidence is essential in a technical role, since the person on the call is the expert in the room even when the customer has more general industry experience
- Admitting uncertainty and following up with the right answer is more effective long term than guessing, and builds a personal knowledge base over time
- Reaching out to other internal teams, including marketing, support, and customer success, is a valuable and underused resource throughout the sales process

7/16 – Intro to the SEs

Speakers: Brendan Paul, Luis Garcia, Osandy

What Makes a Great Solutions Engineer

- **Problem solver** – customers come with real issues, and the SE's job is to understand the pain point and tailor a solution rather than deliver a generic pitch
- **Trusted advisor** – clients rely on the SE to validate the solution, guide them through proof of concepts, and build the technical confidence needed to move forward
- **Technical expert** – the SE is expected to be the authority on the product, whether that is Argos, Form Fusion, or Intelligence
- The SE role goes beyond product knowledge alone, since being a people person and building trust with the client matters just as much as technical mastery
- A core part of the role is acting as a bridge between highly technical stakeholders, such as IT teams, and non-technical end users who simply want their reports to work
- SEs work across nearly every department, including sales, engineering, professional services, and support, since they are the client-facing technical resource throughout the process
- Trust is often extended to SEs more readily than to salespeople, since SEs are expected to prove technical claims rather than simply assert them, which can open doors with IT leadership that then extend to the rest of the institution

What Skills Matter Most

- **Communication** was identified as the most important skill, since even strong technical knowledge is not useful if it cannot be translated to the audience in the room
- **Empathy** matters because customers are looking for someone who understands their frustration, not just someone reciting features
- **Problem solving** was identified as a close second, since clients often bring in their most complex reporting challenges, not simple ones, and expect the SE to find a workable solution
- Technical skills themselves are considered learnable over time through continued training and practice, whereas communication, empathy, and problem solving form the foundation the rest is built on

The Customer Journey

- The journey begins when an institution identifies a challenge, such as reporting problems, and meets with an account executive for discovery
- The SE steps in to design a solution tailored to the specific pain points identified during discovery
- The demo is built to highlight exactly those pain points, weaving in details mentioned during discovery to show the client they were heard
- Technical validation with the IT team is a critical step, since IT will ultimately implement and maintain the solution and needs confidence that it will not create additional burden
- After a successful demo and validation, the process moves into implementation, followed by long-term customer success
- Detailed notes from the sales process, including what the client said they wanted to prioritize, should be passed along clearly to professional services so nothing has to be repeated or rediscovered during implementation

Trust Wins Deals

- Customers build trust in an SE who listens more than they talk, asks helpful and specific questions, and is honest about what the product can and cannot do
- Admitting a lack of knowledge, then following through with an accurate answer later, builds

more trust than pretending to know everything

- Explaining why something works, not just confirming that it does, gives clients more confidence that the solution will actually fit their situation
- Customers lose trust when an SE interrupts or jumps into a demo before fully understanding the need, oversells or exaggerates capabilities, dismisses concerns, ignores red flags, or promises features that do not exist
- Reputational damage travels between institutions in higher education, so a broken promise at one school can make it harder to close deals elsewhere

The Demo as a Story

- A demo should not be a list of features, it should follow a structure: understand the current state, understand the challenge, demonstrate the solution to that specific challenge, and show the resulting business outcome
- Tying the demo directly back to the client's stated pain points, rather than presenting a generic walkthrough, is what makes the story land

Winning as One Team

- Every stage of the customer journey, from first contact through long-term success, depends on smooth handoffs between the AE, SE, professional services, and support
- A poor handoff, such as professional services not having the client's stated priorities on hand, damages client confidence and can make the client feel like they have to start over
- When one team drops the ball, it makes the job harder for every team that follows, and the client tends to remember the negative experience over any individual team that performed well
- Consistent collaboration across departments protects the client relationship and the company's reputation as a whole, not just the outcome of a single deal

Discovery Activity: Understand Before You Solve

- Interns practiced building discovery questions for a scenario where a client described their reporting process as very manual
- Sample questions generated included how much time is spent on manual reporting, what the manual process actually looks like step by step, how often reports are run, what happens when a report is delayed, and what an ideal reporting experience would look like
- The larger principle emphasized was to listen first and recommend second, since the stated problem is often a symptom of a larger, underlying issue that discovery questions are meant to uncover
- A related scenario focused on a registrar's office needing faster enrollment reporting during registration, with example follow-up questions including how enrollment reports are created today and how fast the current process runs
- Additional discovery angles suggested included who relies on the reports, how frequently the data needs to be refreshed, what decisions depend on the information, and how the client prefers to receive and view the report, such as an automated email, a dashboard, or an exported file

7/17 – Emotional Intelligence in Sales & Selling Yourself, Philanthropy

Emotional Intelligence in Sales

Speaker: Mike (Sales Leadership)

Sales Stereotypes

- People buy on emotion and justify the decision afterward with logic, which is why building an emotional connection matters more than reciting features
- Prospects can sense when a salesperson is focused on their own quota or commission rather than the customer's actual problem, and that awareness closes deals off quickly
- Emotionally detaching from the outcome of a deal, while staying genuinely focused on the customer's challenge, is what separates a trusted advisor from a typical high-pressure salesperson
- Interactions that feel purely transactional lead customers to perceive the salesperson as indifferent to their real needs

The Sales Process

- B2B sales, which is what this company practices, differs from B2C sales by involving multiple stakeholders, longer timelines, and custom-built solutions rather than single-person, high-pressure transactions
- The five stages of a sales process are prospecting, qualifying, presenting or demonstrating, handling objections, and closing
- Qualifying was identified as the single most important stage, since a salesperson's time is limited and unqualified deals waste time that could go toward deals that can actually close
- A qualified opportunity needs both a genuine business need and a real consequence tied to a timeline, since a deadline with no consequence for missing it is not a true deadline
- Prospecting must be protected as a recurring, non-negotiable block of time, since even winning a deal removes it from the pipeline and the pipeline must be continually refilled
- Revenue generating activities, such as prospecting and demos, should make up the large majority of a salesperson's time, with administrative tasks kept to a minimum
- Thorough discovery before a demo, including multi-threading into different stakeholders such as IT, finance, and enrollment, produces a far stronger and more tailored presentation than waiting to learn everyone's priorities during the demo itself

Argos vs the Status Quo

- In most B2B markets, the biggest competitor is not a named competitor but the status quo, meaning the prospect decides to do nothing
- Competing purely on features against a named competitor often leads to a feature-by-feature bake-off, since many competing products can perform similar functions
- Framing the conversation around cost of inaction encourages prospects to move away from indecision rather than only comparing vendors

Power Messaging

- Leading with the customer's underlying challenges, goals, and desired outcomes, rather than product features, creates a higher caliber conversation with senior leadership
- Framing conversations around measurable outcomes, such as faster registration or higher graduation rates, helps a prospect visualize achieving their goals through the partnership before the demo even happens

- By the time a prospect reaches the demo, they should already be emotionally invested, and the demo simply shows them how the outcome will be delivered

The Value Wedge

- Many salespeople focus on what is important to the prospect and what the product can do, without considering what a competitor can also do, which does not differentiate the offer
- The value wedge is the space where three conditions overlap: the value is important to the prospect, unique to the vendor, and defensible with credibility and proof
- Only claims that satisfy all three conditions should be the core points emphasized in a sales conversation

Leveraging Emotional Intelligence

- Differentiating from a typical sales interaction, rather than following the expected script, helps a salesperson stand out and be remembered
- Making a prospect feel important through genuine interest and active listening builds trust faster than pitching too early
- Cognitive dissonance can be used constructively, such as getting a prospect to describe why their own company is better than competitors, which makes it harder for them to later claim all vendors are the same
- Directly challenging a prospect's positive opinion of a competitor tends to create an adversarial dynamic, since people defend decisions they believe were logical; asking what they like about the competitor instead can let them naturally recall drawbacks on their own
- People are more receptive to a conclusion when they feel they arrived at it themselves rather than being told directly
- Responding in an unexpected way to common objections, such as being told a prospect is too busy, can lower defenses more effectively than arguing against the objection
- Opening a call with a compelling, specific question rather than generic small talk makes a conversation more memorable
- Empathy remains a foundational skill throughout every stage of the process

Selling Yourself in an Interview

- The moment an interviewer asks if the candidate has questions is one of the most valuable opportunities in the interview, and should not be wasted on generic questions about culture or benefits
- Strong questions focus on the interviewer's goals, biggest challenges, and vision for the role, which allows the candidate to align their own value with what the interviewer actually needs
- Sample questions include asking about top goals for the next six months to a year, the biggest obstacles to achieving them, how the new hire could make an impact in the first 90 days, and what a high performer in the role actually looks like
- Asking how achieving those goals would affect the perception of the interviewer's department or standing within the company adds a further layer of insight into what truly matters to them
- These questions apply the same emotional intelligence principles used in sales, helping the candidate be remembered and positioning them as someone who understands and cares about the interviewer's success

Philanthropy

Speakers: Teresa (Session Lead), Isabella Jones and Connor Jones (Sweet Eats Foundation founders)

Guest Q&A: Sweet Eats Foundation

- Sweet Eats Foundation is a family foundation started by siblings Isabella and Connor Jones, focused on youth development, technology access, and cancer relief, with the cancer relief focus rooted in the loss of their father
- Networking and word of mouth, rather than formal marketing, were described as the main way the foundation connects with new grantee organizations and referral partners
- Deciding which applicants receive funding was described as one of the hardest parts of the work, especially when comparing genuinely deserving cases against each other, such as different cancer relief applicants
- The foundation uses a grant management platform to standardize applications, then scores each one against a shared set of criteria before board discussion, which helps balance individual judgment with group input
- Disagreements between the founders on which organization to fund were described as valuable rather than purely difficult, since working through differing opinions led to better-informed decisions over time
- Balancing immediate relief against long-term impact was described as a case-by-case judgment rather than a fixed rule, with financial relief often providing shorter-term help and youth development or capacity-building grants aimed at more lasting change
- Budget cuts affecting the broader nonprofit sector were noted as a current challenge, prompting foundations to collaborate and pool resources more than before

Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR)

- CSR refers to the ways a company creates positive social impact, including employee volunteering, corporate philanthropy, sustainability efforts, ethical sourcing, and community partnerships
- Companies that practice strong CSR are often described as caring about the triple bottom line, meaning people, planet, and profit rather than profit alone
- CSR matters increasingly because today's workforce tends to prefer purpose-driven companies with ethical leadership and genuine community engagement
- Strong CSR examples include offering free tools to nonprofits, hiring justice-involved individuals, funding causes tied to product purchases, and setting concrete sustainability or representation targets
- A commonly cited CSR failure involved a company selling a celebratory product tied to a solemn historical event, which drew criticism for appearing to profit from something painful rather than genuinely honoring it

Common CSR Areas

- Diversity, equity, inclusion, and belonging (DEIB), though funding in this area has decreased in recent years due to shifting political and administrative priorities
- Employee engagement and corporate volunteering programs
- Environmental sustainability and ethical supply chain practices, including awareness of how sourcing and shipping affect carbon emissions
- Governance and accountability, ensuring fair treatment and compensation practices between leadership and other employees

CSR Initiatives and Practices

- Common initiatives include volunteer days, employee-led fundraising, charity walks or runs, mentoring and tutoring programs, direct donations, and charity event sponsorships
- Event sponsorship provides brand visibility alongside the charitable contribution, which can

also support the sponsoring company's own reputation and business development

- **ESG (Environmental, Social, Governance)** is a broader framework describing whether a company is environmentally conscious, socially responsible, and fair in its leadership and compensation practices

eVisions CSR

- eVisions runs an annual Month of Giving after Thanksgiving through December, during which employees volunteer in their communities and share their activity on an internal Slack channel
- Past projects have included work with a family shelter for homeless youth and families, mentoring and mock interviews for students, and holiday crafts and reading with local schools
- Each employee receives eight hours of paid work time per year specifically for community volunteering
- An effective CSR strategy blends company values, employee values, and client values, and should feel like an authentic mindset rather than a public relations campaign

CSR Engagement Strategy

- Strategies generally draw on a combination of time, money, and skills, sometimes summarized as talent, treasure, and time
- Common tactics include employer-matched employee donations, charity walks or runs, and skill-sharing volunteer work, such as employees conducting mock interviews for a partner nonprofit's program
- Effective strategies make participation easy and enjoyable for employees and offer incentives rather than simply mandating involvement

Nonprofit Idol Project Assignment

- Each intern will select a nonprofit organization in their community that they are personally passionate about
- Research should include the nonprofit's mission, tax identification number, annual budget, target population, geographic location, program services, and current needs such as funding, volunteers, or in-kind donations
- Candid was recommended as a free research resource for nonprofit financial and programmatic information, with a direct call to the organization as a backup if information cannot be found online
- Each intern will build a one to two page slide presenting their selected nonprofit, including a proposed CSR engagement strategy for how eVisions could realistically get involved
- Interns will present their nonprofit to the group, vote on one, and the selected organization will be presented again during the capstone presentation
- The assignment is due the following Thursday